

How Do I Take the Low Room?

Phase Two Begins When His Love Can Flow Through You

You are ready to take this a step further in contending for revival, from phase one to phase two.

I will remind you that phase one is where His love flows to you, preparing you for phase two, where His love flows through you. He loves you as much as the people He wants to save. He loves you as much as the people He wants to heal.

When you come into phase two, where His love flows through you, that is a place in God of intercession and ministry where He can place you between hell and people who are trying to get there, and actually have results produced because of it.

When this stage begins to take place, you are going to attract powers, principalities, and spiritual wickedness. They are going to be as determined to stop you as you are to stop them.

In phase one, His love flows to you to build you up to the place where His love can flow through you. That phase is intercession. It will not matter how many devils from hell you attract. In phase two, you will have such a foundation that He can pour hell on you, and no obstacle will be too great for you to survive and pray your way through.

That, my folks, is what revival is made out of: your determination.

What we are studying now is how to get you out of phase one. It has been fun, has it not?

Open to Luke 14. We are going to begin with verse 28. Tonight we are going to talk about exaltation.

Do you want to be exalted in His kingdom? You might as well be humble and say yes. I would be lying to you if I told you I did not want to learn to stand in the gap between cities going to hell and revival, and take a couple of million people home with me in these next few years. I do. That is a humble statement.

To humble yourself means to become one thousand percent teachable.

So you want to learn how exaltation comes in the kingdom, and the Bible says you must humble yourself.

We are talking about being exalted out of phase one into phase two, where His love can flow through you. People tell me all the time, "I have these problems. I have this job. I have all these things."

All you should do is look at those things as obstacles that simply have to be overcome in the process of revival.

"But you do not understand my situation."

Yes, I do. You are like the ten thousand before you who never had revival.

Counting the Cost Means Deciding Whether Jesus Is Enough

Luke 14:28 says:

For which of you, intending to build a tower, sitteth not down first, and counteth the cost, whether he have sufficient to finish it?

Lest haply, after he hath laid the foundation, and is not able to finish it, all that behold it begin to mock him,

Saying, This man began to build, and was not able to finish.

Or what king, going to make war against another king, sitteth not down first, and consulteth whether he be able with ten thousand to meet him that cometh against him with twenty thousand?

Or else, while the other is yet a great way off, he sendeth an ambassage, and desireth conditions of peace.

Then Jesus said something outstanding. I do not mind telling you it took me probably four years of meditation to understand this chapter, and the understanding of it came in phases. But I am more convinced than ever before that he who hungers and thirsts after righteousness shall be filled.

That hungering and thirsting is like sitting down to a meal. That meal does not satisfy me for the rest of my life. I get hungry again and again. He who hungers and thirsts after righteousness will be fed and given drink time after time, as often as his heart desires, hungers, and thirsts.

Jesus said:

So likewise, whosoever he be of you that forsaketh not all that he hath, he cannot be my disciple.

Salt is good: but if the salt have lost his savour, wherewith shall it be seasoned?

It is neither fit for the land, nor yet for the dunghill; but men cast it out. He that hath ears to hear, let him hear.

The word "likewise" is a comparative word. Jesus says, "Which of you, intending to build a tower, does not sit down first and count the cost to see whether he has enough to finish it?"

Which of you would not sit down and do the sensible thing? You would count the cost right down to the last nail. You would include inflation. You would consider the time the building would be finished. In the natural, which of you would not sit down and count the cost to see whether you had enough to finish the tower?

Then He says a king going to war against another king would consult to see whether his ten thousand could meet the other man's twenty thousand. If he found out he could not overcome that army, he would send ambassadors and desire conditions of peace.

What Jesus was saying is this: if you do not forsake all to become His disciple, His disciplined follower, you will be as mis-equipped as the man who did not count the cost. Everyone who saw what he began to build also saw that he did not have enough to finish it, and they began to mock him.

Likewise, everyone who does not forsake all he has to become His disciplined follower is like the man who had nowhere to go for counsel to know whether to go against twenty thousand with ten thousand or send ambassadors and desire conditions of peace.

If you do not forsake all you have to become His disciple, you are going to be just like the man who did not have enough to finish his tower. You are going to be just like the man who had nowhere to go for counsel to save his life.

Jesus said salt is good, but if salt loses its flavor, where will you go to season it back to salt again?

Wake up. You think you are successful. You think you can fight things out on your own. You think you can walk in the natural and accomplish the mission of the church of the Lord Jesus Christ. But if salt loses its flavor, where will you go to season it back again?

Outside of Jesus Christ, in this entire universe, where are you going to go to replace what He is in your life? Where are you going to get a replacement?

The tower He is talking about is your life. The tower He is talking about is your ministry. The tower He is talking about is success or failure. It is the life you are building in Jesus Christ.

So counting the cost to see whether you have enough to finish is counting whether you are going to forsake all that you have to follow Jesus. You are deciding whether you are going to have enough to finish your tower when you decide whether you will forsake all to follow Him.

I did not say it would be easy to come to this center. But we will guarantee you will walk where you have never walked before, because we are going to make you tough.

Do not get scared by this talk of forsaking all that you have to be His disciple. A disciple is a disciplined follower of Jesus.

What are we all looking for anyway? A life in Jesus. Why do you sit in church every Sunday? Why do you sit in church every Wednesday? Yes, you love God. But what are you looking for?

Are you not looking for the equipment to finish your tower? Are you not reaching for enough material to finish and succeed in this life? I can guarantee you there is nothing you want that Jesus has not provided the answer for in His Word.

So let us look closely at what it means to humble ourselves. If you and I can figure out what it means to humble ourselves, and then do it, there is not a thing this side of hell the devil can do about it. We are going to experience the exaltation that comes from God, the kind that says, "Here you are. Here is all the building material you need in this life. Finish your tower."

God Exalts the Teachable, Not the Self-Promoted

Back up to Luke 14:11:

For whosoever exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

It did not take me long--only three or four years--to figure out that this verse was talking about exaltation that comes to a man in the kingdom.

We know God resists the proud and gives grace to the humble. The proud are unteachable. Therefore the humble man is one thousand percent teachable.

If this is talking about exaltation in the kingdom of God, and we know it is, then let us find out what kind of exaltation He is talking about. When Jesus wound this message up, He guaranteed me that if I choose Him, I will not only have enough to finish my tower, but I will have the counsel I need to succeed.

Verse 12 says:

Then said he also to him that bade him, When thou makest a dinner or a supper, call not thy friends, nor thy brethren, neither thy kinsmen, nor thy rich neighbours; lest they also bid thee again, and a recompence be made thee.

If He is talking about exaltation that comes to a man in the kingdom from humbling himself, notice this. He said not to invite your friends, kinsmen, and rich neighbors because they can make recompense back to you.

Under those circumstances, the motivation of the heart is your own exaltation. You invite people who can pay you back. The motivation is not their exaltation; it is your own.

Lord, I have seen enough of that. Do not get me into that.

Thank God there is still an exaltation that comes from Him. I do not care how sharp you are, how well you can connive and scheme, how charismatic you are, or how well you can pull the wool over people's eyes. You are not getting anywhere with God. Those tactics do not work with Him.

Why do you think men form denominations? Denominations are often schisms.

"We cannot agree with you anymore. You are not as godly as you used to be. We are going down the street and starting another one."

When Paul was teaching on communion, division, and why communion was not working, he said, "I hear there are divisions among you, and I partly believe it." If there are divisions, there are schisms. There have to be leaders to the divisions so those who are approved might be revealed or made manifest among you.

In other words, if God is not exalting me, I will have to form some kind of denomination. Men will do it. If God is not doing it, the best thing to do is get a group of people together and say, "I am the boss. Bow when you come in."

The Lord was talking to me the other day and said, "You are going to draw some fire."

I said, "You and I both know that is not new."

He said, "I want you to know it is a small thing for a man to stand up and say, 'I am this and I am that,' and then get a following and judge your walk with God according to the bylaws, governments, and teachings set forth in that body."

We can exalt ourselves all day long, but a man is not really qualified for ministry until the Holy Spirit qualifies him. This is what Paul was talking about when he talked about the operations of God. Jesus ascended on high and gave offices and gifts unto men. God is in charge of operations, and operations are a blend of the nine gifts and the five offices. They are what qualify an office. If God does not put a man in, he is not in.

He that humbles himself will be exalted. He that exalts himself will be abased.

The Exalted Church Serves the Poor, Maimed, Lame, and Blind

When you invite your friends to come to a dinner, Jesus said not to invite your rich neighbors and kinsmen for recompense. That is self-exaltation. You will do for them as long as they will do for you.

Then He said, "Let Me show you what kind of exaltation comes to a man in the kingdom."

Only God can exalt you to this place.

Luke 14:13-14 says:

But when thou makest a feast, call the poor, the maimed, the lame, the blind:

And thou shalt be blessed; for they cannot recompense thee: for thou shalt be recompensed at the resurrection of the just.

What kind of dinner or supper is He talking about if this is in correlation with a man who humbles himself and gets exalted in the kingdom of God?

I can tell you what kind. When you prepare a dinner and say, "Come," He says these are the ones He wants you to invite: the halt, the maimed, the lame, and the blind. The dinner you are asking them to come to is the dinner prepared by God for the world through the Lord Jesus Christ.

When He says, "Come to the dinner," He is saying, "Come, for there has been a dinner prepared for the world by God through the Lord Jesus Christ. Come and eat."

Notice whom He invites to eat from the dinner table of the Lord Jesus Christ: the maimed, the halt, the lame, and the blind.

Why?

Because from the exalted position of the Holy Spirit, the place where the church is to walk, the halt do not have to be halted by disease anymore. The maimed do not have to be maimed anymore. The lame do not have to be lame anymore. The blind do not have to be blind anymore.

From the exalted position of the Holy Spirit, where the church has been called to serve, the invitation is, "Come and eat from the table. Blind, you do not have to be blind. Healing has been prepared for you through the table of the Lord Jesus Christ, and we are His waiters. Come and eat, for we are about to serve you from an exalted place that only Jesus can give."

That means if I truly learn from the Holy Spirit how to humble myself, then I am lining myself up in God in such a way that I know my exaltation will come from Him.

Government is of God, but if I form a government so I can be the dominant head of it, that is exaltation that men give. It may be accepted by men, but it does not replace the exaltation God gives.

Poor, maimed, lame, and blind: come. A table has been prepared for you by God through the Lord Jesus Christ, and at this table is a feast of healing. Blind, you do not have to be blind anymore. Poor, you do not have to be poor anymore. From that exalted position, the church can serve the world.

This makes me want to know more than ever how to humble myself.

The Low Room Is the Place Where God Can Publicly Say, "Friend, Go Up Higher"

We do not have to go far. Look again at verse 11:

For whosoever exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

The first word is "for." "For whosoever..." means, "Based on what I have already said, I am going to say this." That means the verses leading up to verse 11 must give me information on how to humble myself.

Look at verse 7:

And he put forth a parable to those which were bidden, when he marked how they chose out the chief rooms; saying unto them...

What is a parable? It is something I can understand with my natural mind, but it is designed to illustrate a spiritual application. Jesus used parables as valuable teaching tools. The kingdom of God is as a mustard seed. The kingdom of God is as fish gathered in a net. The kingdom of God is as a householder, a treasure hidden in a field, a pearl of great price.

All these things can be understood with the natural mind, but they are designed to illustrate a spiritual application.

So if verse 11 is dealing with true exaltation that comes to a man in the kingdom, and Jesus speaks a parable in verse 7, then if I can understand the parable, I can understand how exaltation comes to a man in the kingdom.

Verse 8 says:

When thou art bidden of any man to a wedding, sit not down in the highest room; lest a more honourable man than thou be bidden of him;

And he that bade thee and him come and say to thee, Give this man place; and thou begin with shame to take the lowest room.

But when thou art bidden, go and sit down in the lowest room; that when he that bade thee cometh, he may say unto thee, Friend, go up higher: then shalt thou have worship in the presence of them that sit at meat with thee.

For whosoever exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

When God lays His hand on a man and says, "Friend, come up higher," you will have worship in the presence of those who sit at meat with you.

He did not mean the kind of worship we teach in the service, where we worship God. He meant that you will have the admiration of men to such a degree that they burst out in thankfulness and excitement over what God is doing in your life.

When God begins to exalt a man, you will have worship in the presence of those you eat meat with, or those you do daily affairs and business with. For the people around you to get excited about what is happening in your life, your exaltation has to be evident.

Something has to be going on that is evident to everyone around you. I do not mind that kind of exaltation.

Yesterday I owed fifty thousand dollars. Today I have fifty thousand dollars in the bank. That is worth listening to.

We do not have a problem. We have answers.

When He says if you humble yourself, if you become one thousand percent teachable, then your exaltation will be so evident that people will want to run up and praise God for your life and testimony, that makes me want to pitch my tent, drive the stakes into this chapter, and meditate until I understand how to humble myself. I want to understand once and for all how exaltation comes.

It will be so evident that those we minister to in daily affairs will get excited, because the fact will be evident that God has laid His hand on your life.

I know how Jesus humbled Himself. But my instruction was to take the low room.

I understand the parable: when He invited them to dinner or supper, those who took the chief room were de-exalted, and those who took the low room were exalted. I understand that in principle.

What I really wanted to know in my spirit was this: What is the low room?

The problem is not whether we want to take it. The problem is understanding how to take the low room, because Jesus guaranteed that by taking the low room you would end up with enough building materials to finish your tower.

Jesus Took the Lowest Position to Reveal How Deeply We Are Loved

I know what low room Jesus took. He humbled Himself and was found in fashion as a man, obedient to the cross. He took the lowest position in the universe and was exalted to the highest at the right hand of God the Father.

When I was having trouble understanding the love of God, and trouble loving God's people, God had to take me quite a ways into the cross to show me the love He had for me.

I never had a father. He left, and I had many "daddies," mostly alcoholics my mother stayed with for two or three months at a time. My childhood memories of my many daddies were of begging them to take me fishing or do things a regular father would do.

So I had no concept of father and no concept of love.

My mother was a periodic alcoholic all her life. She could only take life's pressure so long before she would break under it and go on an alcoholic binge, disappearing for two or three months at a time.

They moved us in with Grandpa. He took us in when I was around the second or third grade. When Mom would go on those binges, I would be with Grandpa, an aunt, and an uncle.

Grandpa was an old Missourian. He was good to us, but he had something of a temper from Missouri. I reminded him of my old man. I looked just like him. I guess I had some of his mannerisms. I did not know him, but Grandpa did.

Sometimes when I would not do something just right, he would scream and yell at me, "You are going to be just like old man Roberson. He is never going to amount to a thing."

My father made his living robbing gas stations and grocery stores. He had been in prison most of his life. After I answered the call, I found out my dad was a preacher's kid and that his father had been a tent evangelist. I did not even know it until I was preaching, after someone had prayed a call on me and I answered it.

So I did not know much about love.

You want to talk about Jesus humbling Himself and finding Himself in fashion as a man? Seeing Jesus hanging on the cross was bad enough. Isaiah says His visage was marred more than any man, and His form more than the sons of men.

When I actually saw a vision come through my spirit, it shook me so badly that it jolted me out of the Spirit. I saw a man hanging on the cross so disfigured, so drawn up, so hideous that you could not even tell it was a man hanging there.

The reason I did not know at first that it was Jesus was because my conception of Jesus crucified had been an artist's conception. That was nowhere near what was hanging on the cross that day.

At the moment He cried, "My God, why hast Thou forsaken Me?" and the Holy Spirit withdrew, He became your sin and my sin, every damnable thing we were. You would not want that moment hanging on your wall, when your sin met up with Him.

And that was not the end of it. He took the lowest position in the universe.

As Jonah was in the belly of the whale three days and three nights, so must the Son of Man be in the center of the earth.

That night I was still wrestling with the love of God, and I found out the reason I could not love with the love He talked about in the Word was because I did not yet have a revelation of how much I was loved. Just recently He has taken me a step further into a foundation of peace and explained the love of God to me a little further, but then I was not even at first base. I was the arrogant, bold, brazen faith man.

But I saw Him.

I was preaching Kenneth Copeland's message. I had Jesus in hell and was ready to get Him out. People were excited. I was talking about hell, the torment, the attack of demonic principalities and powers, and the war waged in the pits of hell.

Just as I was about to get Him out, I lapsed into a vision. I was standing there with my mouth open, suspended before the crowd. I saw a man lying in a cavern flat on his back, with his hands extended, opening and closing his hands, shaking and crying, "Help me."

To all appearance there were nine-inch slithery worms crawling all over his body. It looked like they were in his eyes, nose, and mouth. He was screaming in agony, shaking all over his body, crying, "Help me. Help me."

When I came out of the vision, I did not know where I was for a moment. When the crowd materialized in front of me again, I was looking at them and they were looking at me. I thought, "Where am I? What happened?"

I came to myself, and slowly my memory came back. I realized that in the message I had just put Jesus in the place Jonah was: three days and three nights in the belly of the earth, what was later called the belly of hell. I had just put Him there in my message, and then I lapsed into this vision.

When I came out of it, I said, "Lord, You do not understand. I just put Jesus in the lower regions of darkness, and You are trying to tell me through a vision that this is my Jesus lying there prostrate on His back, hands extended, screaming in agony, with worms crawling all over His body?"

Listen, either He went to that place or He did not. If He did, He did not go for a picnic. He was screaming in agony. Absolute agony.

I said, "I will have to have Scripture." So He gave them to me:

They shall be cast into outer darkness: there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

And:

Their worm dieth not.

He was being eaten from the inside out by my sin. Every damnable torment that could ever be dreamed up or schemed up was being laid on Him for three horrible, unspeakable days and nights as He suffered the penalty of becoming my abomination.

He not only became my sin, my friend; He suffered the penalties for becoming it.

I ministered to a man in prison who had murdered seven people. I had trouble with it. I thought, "This guy really needs to be put to death, his fingernails pulled out, and tortured real slowly."

But Jesus said, "Do you know why he is as free as you are? Sure, he deserves punishment. Sure, he deserves to be afflicted. But every damnable piece of torment that man had coming was allowed to be poured on Me for three days and three nights when I suffered in your place, when I was made your sin and became an abomination."

From that day forth, I knew I was loved.

Although Jesus humbled Himself to the lowest position in the universe, He was also exalted to the highest as Lord Advocate at the right hand of God the Father.

Now I know I am not Jesus. I am not qualified to suffer redemptively for my own sin. I am not qualified to bear my own sins. I am not qualified even to bear my own poverty.

My question was: if He humbled Himself and became every damnable thing I was, how do I humble myself?

The word "humble" means to become teachable, one thousand percent teachable.

Taking the Low Room Is Choosing Jesus Over Every Claim of the Old Life

Go to the end of the chapter, Luke 14:24:

For I say unto you, That none of those men which were bidden shall taste of my supper.
And there went great multitudes with him: and he turned, and said unto them...

Remember, Jesus is still teaching on this: if you humble yourself, you will be exalted. He is still talking about suppers. He has never changed the subject. He is talking about bidding people to come to the table prepared by the Lord Jesus Christ.

A great multitude went with Him, and He turned and said:

If any man come to me, and hate not his father, and mother, and wife, and children, and brethren, and sisters, yea, and his own life also, he cannot be my disciple.
And whosoever doth not bear his cross, and come after me, cannot be my disciple.

Here is how you humble yourself.

I know how Jesus humbled Himself, but I am looking for how to take the low room. I want to know what it is, because I want to know how to humble myself.

Jesus says if any man comes to Him and hates not his father, mother, wife, children, brothers, sisters, and his own life also, he cannot be His disciple.

You know as well as I do from the rest of the Word of God that the hate He is talking about cannot be the kind of hate that says, "I hate your guts." It cannot be the violent, variance kind of hate that goes on so much in the body of Christ.

But He was talking about a word that carried force, emotion, and vehemence. It entailed a powerful, vehement decision.

In comparison to your mother, brothers, sisters, and even your own life, next to Jesus Christ, you are to love Him as though you hate them. When your love for Him is compared with your love for them, their place would look like hate.

In other words, it is a violent, emphatic, no-hesitation choice to choose Jesus over everything that exists. That includes your own life also.

Whoever comes to Him and does not bear his cross and follow Him cannot be His disciple.

Do you know what a man does on a cross? He dies.

This is why, in this violent, vehement decision, He says, "Do you really want to know how to humble yourself to where you will be exalted? Choose Me over everything that exists, even over your own life."

When you pick up your cross, you might as well hate your old life, because that is why you picked up the cross. That is where the old man is crucified.

I was watching a television program one time. A woman who was blind was being interviewed, and the interviewer said, "You know, God can heal you."

She jumped back like someone had stuck her with a branding iron and said, "Oh no. This is my cross. How can I minister to the blind unless I am blind?"

That thinking may seem honorable. Thank God for a woman willing to sacrifice like that. But that is not the cross Jesus was talking about, because the cross He is talking about is something I can pick up. I pick it up. That is why He gave you the choice.

He says that if any man comes to Him and hates not father, mother, wife, children, and his own life also, he cannot be His disciple; because if you are going to be His disciple, you have to pick up your cross and follow Him.

So you might as well hate your own life also--the flesh, the pride of this world, the achievements of this world, and everything this world has to offer. If you are going to be exalted, the old man is going to die on the cross.

If I can pick the cross up, I can lay it down. But disease, blindness, and the things the devil brings are imposed on you by force. The cross is something Jesus asks you to pick up. If you can pick it up, you can lay it down any time you want. What the devil imposes on you, you cannot lay down any time you want.

The cross is tied to your free will as a moral agent. If you can pick it up, you can lay it down. It is your choice to pick it up. That is what He is talking about when He talks about humbling yourself.

He did not tell you to hate your wife, mother, children, and brothers in the sense you are thinking. He is not telling you to forsake them in order to choose Him. The next verse says:

For which of you, intending to build a tower, sitteth not down first, and counteth the cost, whether he have sufficient to finish it?

By choosing Jesus, you are not going to lose your wife, brothers, sisters, lands, houses, or anything else. When you choose Him, you humble yourself. If you humble yourself, He exalts you. If He exalts you, you will have enough to finish your tower.

You will have enough to win your wife, not lose her. You will have enough to win your brothers, sisters, mothers, and fathers, not lose them.

If you humble yourself, you will be exalted. If you exalt yourself, you will be abased.

I cannot go to the cross for myself. I am not qualified to suffer for myself. He has already done that. The most humble act you can execute is to choose violently, vehemently, without hesitation, and with force what He has done for you. Choose Jesus to such a degree that you hate your own life.

He is talking about mortification: the death of the old man and its control over you, and all the things of this life that the Gentiles seek after.

When you start dying out to these things, He says, "Pick up your cross and follow Me." Then He says you will have enough to finish your tower. Because you chose Jesus, you will have counsel to know whether to go against the king with twenty thousand using your ten thousand, or to stay home and send ambassadors of peace.

Because you chose Jesus, you not only have enough building materials; you have counsel to know whether to go or not.

So likewise, if any one of you does not forsake all that he has and become His disciple, salt is good, but if salt loses its savor, where will you go to season it back?

Outside of Jesus, where are you going to go to replace what He is in your life?

To humble myself is to choose Him. If we learn how to humble ourselves, He will give us enough building material to take this city.

Self-Exaltation Uses People; True Exaltation Serves Them

I like what Jesus said about the supper. When you invite someone to your supper, do not invite your rich kinsmen and neighbors, because the real motivation of your heart is self-exaltation: "I will do for you as long as you can do for me."

I like what Jesus said about the cross, about picking it up and following Him, and about ensuring that you would have enough building material to finish your tower.

Everything that constitutes failure will die with the old man on the cross. That is why He said to pick it up. Everything that constitutes failure will die there.

How many of you have ever been de-exalted? I have been there once or twice. Believe me, I would rather stay around exaltation.

When the exaltation that comes from choosing Jesus begins to come into a person's life, it will come all the way to the degree that He says, "To My supper, you can invite the halt, maimed, lame, and blind."

You know as well as I do that this exaltation comes from the throne and the throne room alone. You cannot conjure it up. You cannot muster it up. You cannot make it happen. It has to be the pure exaltation of God.

When a person begins to take the high room and Jesus did not put him there, then he is exalting himself. Let me show you what can happen if you have exalted yourself.

There is a form of ministry Jesus just will not let me do. I have come close enough to operating in the flesh before that now it appalls me. I get sick inside when I even think about it.

I have been pressured by my budget before, and I justified myself by saying, "Roberson, are you not called to preach? My God, you are running out of money. After all, are you not really called to preach?"

So I justified my call by saying, "You are really called to preach. That is what you should be doing anyway: winning the lost, getting them filled with the Holy Ghost." But really, what I was going for was that my budget was not going to make it to the next meeting, which was a week or two away.

In one way or another, you become a hireling.

You can tell when pressure begins to show up on a man. It amazes me how many preachers who get into financial problems are suddenly called to teach on prosperity.

Have you ever noticed that?

I think the time to preach on prosperity is when you are walking in it, not when you are in trouble. If you are going to give me a prosperity seminar, I would like to see that you have more than money in your pocket. I would like to see your check stubs for the last year. Maybe you made two or three million; I would like to see the stubs. Then I will listen to your seminar.

We mistake faith many times for ability. It is pretty bad not to be able to get rich in the United States. People come over from third-world countries and look at everyone and say, "My God." Pretty soon they own your whole block.

If you are going to teach prosperity, I would like to see your giving record. Prosperity is always relative. First I would like to see your check stubs, and second I would like to know inside that you really got it from God, because you can get it from ability.

The difference is this: if you got it from God, He can ask for it and get it back. If He can get it back, He can multiply it and give it to you, and you become a funnel steward He can shift here and there to meet needs in the kingdom.

But if you got it through ability, you hang onto it. He says, "I want your money."

"Well, I have been without it a long time. I think I will hang on to it."

Whether you are rich or poor makes no difference to God if your money is doing the kingdom no good. The poor man is in the same shape as the rich man, because God is concerned with the kingdom and meeting people's needs. Your wealth does not do Him any good if it is not available to Him.

The Rich Young Ruler Tried to Approach Jesus Through Flattery and Influence

Have you ever wondered about the rich young ruler? He said, "Good Master, what good thing must I do to inherit the kingdom?"

Jesus answered, "Why callest thou Me good? There is none good but One, that is, God. You know the commandments."

I used to think, "God, why did You get mad at him? He called You good." I had never seen Jesus do that before.

Then I realized the rich young ruler loved God, yes. But when Jesus asked him to give his money away, he was saying, "Please, Jesus, do not ask. I have that door locked. Please do not ask to come into that room."

Jesus said, "I want your money."

Rich men can be scared of getting saved because they are afraid Jesus will want to come into the room where all the money is locked up.

"Can I come into that room, rich man?"

"No."

So he was exceedingly sorrowful and walked away.

I did not understand what took place there until God began to show me true prosperity.

That rich young ruler loved God. He probably had a lot of Pharisees in his back pocket. If you have fifty to a hundred thousand dollars, I can get you on a couple of major boards of evangelists as an adviser. They will want your advice every time they need more money.

"We need your advice. We are thinking about a crusade in India, and since you are an adviser, we would really like you to pray about it because we are asking all of our partners to pray."

Money talks. It is loaded with power, and it is only as wicked or as good as the person who has the money in his pocket. If you are a rich sinner, you can sin big. If you are a poor sinner, you sin little.

The rich young ruler loved God, and he likely had influence among the Pharisees. Do you not think he had bought his way onto boards? When they had a dinner, guess who got up and gave his testimony: "This is the rich young Pharisee, and he would like to talk to you for a while." Then he makes a big donation right after the talk.

So why not get next to Jesus the same way? A little flattery, a little money.

"Good Master."

Jesus said, "Do not flatter Me. You may have bought the Pharisees, but I am not for sale."

Then He said, "I want you to give your money away."

"There goes another preacher who wants my money."

No. Jesus said to give it to the poor. "I do not want your money. I cannot be bought. Then, if you want to come, follow Me."

Ground Gained by the Flesh Cannot Be Kept From the Devil

You can tell when a preacher gets under pressure. He will shift the pressure to you. He will start using tactics and pressure. Fear, worry, and torment will rack him, build up, and squeeze out of him until he comes to you and starts venting that fear on you.

It becomes your responsibility. Those kids are starving.

But the God I serve can take two fish and five loaves, and He will do that in this ministry before we beg.

When people go to the flesh, they are not going to God. If you go to the flesh, you may be exalted out of the problem, but the trouble is, it is not God who is doing it.

If God is not the one doing it, then when the devil comes to take away the ground you did not get from God by withstanding him, there is nothing this side of hell you can do about it. He will say, "Go back to the low room," and you are going back. There is nothing you can do about it.

There are a lot of men who have been exalted to a place they did not get from God. That is why they fall from it. When Satan comes to get it, they do not have what it takes to withstand him because they did not get it from God and take it away from the devil.

The man who humbles himself crucifies the old man on the cross, including all those handles on the flesh. As God begins to exalt him, the handles die.

Then the devil comes and says, "I do not believe you truly got that new place of exaltation."

You can say, "Devil, try it. If you can find a handle on me to bring me down, bring me down. If you cannot, shut up and get out of my way."

True exaltation comes as the old man dies and the devil loses control over your life through the flesh.

Thank God, in phase one, we are going to have people who learn how to humble themselves. In phase two, we are going to be in the revival of our life.

Did you learn anything tonight?